

GRE-Style Verbal Reasoning Practice Set

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This reader copy places all answer keys and explanations after the questions so you can work through the set before checking solutions.

Contents: 15 Reading Comprehension questions, 9 Text Completion questions, and 6 Sentence Equivalence questions.

Questions

Reading Comprehension

Passage 1

Museum conservators have increasingly used multispectral imaging to study old paintings without removing varnish or sampling pigment. The technique can reveal underdrawings and later revisions, but its results are not self-interpreting. A dark shape beneath a painted surface may indicate an abandoned compositional plan, a repair, or even a stain in a preparatory layer. For this reason, some conservators argue that imaging should be treated less as a decisive diagnostic tool than as a source of hypotheses to be checked against archival records, material analysis, and knowledge of an artist's workshop practices. The most persuasive attributions, in their view, emerge when technical evidence and historical context constrain one another.

rc-001. Which of the following best states the main point of the passage?

- A. Multispectral imaging has made traditional archival research largely unnecessary in conservation work.
- B. Technical imaging is valuable in conservation, but its findings require corroboration from other forms of evidence.
- C. The best way to attribute paintings is to compare their visible style with an artist's authenticated works.
- D. Conservators disagree primarily about whether old varnish should be removed before paintings are studied.
- E. Material analysis is less reliable than imaging because it can damage fragile paintings.

rc-002. The passage suggests that the conservators mentioned would be most skeptical of which of the following claims?

- A. An image beneath the paint surface can sometimes help identify a painter's working method.
- B. A single imaging result can conclusively establish a painting's attribution without further inquiry.
- C. Archival records may help determine whether a painted revision is historically plausible.
- D. A technical finding may prompt researchers to ask new questions about a painting.
- E. Workshop practices can be relevant to interpreting physical evidence in a painting.

rc-003. Based on the passage, which of the following are possible interpretations of a dark shape revealed beneath a painted surface? Select all that apply.

- A. It may be evidence of a composition the artist began but did not complete.

- B. It may result from damage or alteration unrelated to the artist's original design.
- C. It may prove that the visible painting was executed by a different artist.

Passage 2

Urban planners often praise tree-planting campaigns for cooling neighborhoods, but recent monitoring complicates that simple picture. In districts where mature trees shade pavement and buildings throughout the afternoon, average surface temperatures do fall. Yet in narrow streets bordered by tall buildings, dense plantings can reduce air circulation and trap humid air after sunset. The result is that residents may experience less daytime heat but little nighttime relief, a problem for people whose health depends on recovery during cooler hours. Planners therefore increasingly distinguish between adding canopy and designing ventilation corridors. The distinction does not diminish the value of trees; rather, it suggests that vegetation must be placed with attention to street geometry and daily temperature cycles.

rc-004. Which of the following best captures the passage's treatment of urban tree planting?

- A. It rejects tree planting because dense vegetation usually increases heat exposure.
- B. It argues that tree planting is beneficial only in neighborhoods without tall buildings.
- C. It presents tree planting as useful but dependent on local physical conditions.
- D. It maintains that ventilation corridors are less important than maximizing canopy area.
- E. It claims that nighttime heat is caused chiefly by a lack of public health planning.

rc-005. The passage implies that a tree-planting plan would be most vulnerable to criticism if it

- A. gave priority to streets where residents currently have little shade at midday.
- B. used mature species that create afternoon shade on paved surfaces.
- C. treated total canopy coverage as sufficient without considering airflow after sunset.
- D. included measurements of both surface temperature and humidity.
- E. paired vegetation with changes to building materials and pavement color.

rc-006. Select the sentence that most directly states the practical planning conclusion drawn from the evidence in the passage.

- A. Urban planners often praise tree-planting campaigns for cooling neighborhoods, but recent monitoring complicates that simple picture.
- B. In districts where mature trees shade pavement and buildings throughout the afternoon, average surface temperatures do fall.
- C. Yet in narrow streets bordered by tall buildings, dense plantings can reduce air circulation and trap humid air after sunset.
- D. The result is that residents may experience less daytime heat but little nighttime relief, a problem for people whose health depends on recovery during cooler hours.
- E. Planners therefore increasingly distinguish between adding canopy and designing ventilation corridors.
- F. The distinction does not diminish the value of trees; rather, it suggests that vegetation must be placed with attention to street geometry and daily temperature cycles.

Passage 3

A common account of medieval marginal drawings treats them as comic eruptions at the edges of otherwise solemn books. That description is not wrong, but it is incomplete. Marginal images could mock authority, entertain a reader, mark a section for later use, or extend a manuscript's argument by visual analogy. A rabbit hunting a hound, for instance, need not be merely absurd; it might invert a familiar hierarchy and thereby echo a text's interest in worldly instability. Because many manuscripts were collaborative objects, the meaning of a marginal figure may also depend on who added it and when. Treating the margins as decorative leftovers risks missing how actively they could participate in reading.

rc-007. The author of the passage would most likely agree with which of the following statements about medieval marginal drawings?

- A. They should be interpreted as serious theological arguments rather than as humorous images.
- B. Their meaning can be more varied and textually engaged than a purely comic account suggests.
- C. They were usually added by readers long after the manuscript text had ceased to be studied.
- D. Their value lies mainly in showing that medieval artists rejected hierarchy.
- E. They are too ambiguous to support any claim about how manuscripts were read.

rc-008. The example of the rabbit hunting a hound serves primarily to

- A. show that marginal drawings were normally intended to replace written commentary.
- B. illustrate how an apparently comic image could reinforce a manuscript's theme.
- C. demonstrate that animal images were more common than human figures in manuscripts.
- D. identify the earliest known use of visual inversion in manuscript decoration.
- E. suggest that readers preferred images whose meanings were fixed and obvious.

rc-009. According to the passage, which of the following are possible functions of marginal images? Select all that apply.

- A. They could help a reader locate a portion of a manuscript.
- B. They could visually develop an idea present in the manuscript's text.
- C. They could guarantee that all later readers understood a manuscript in the same way.

Passage 4

A nonprofit that delivers meals to older adults recently replaced fixed delivery routes with software that assigns stops each morning. Managers reported that the change shortened average driving time and allowed the same staff to serve more clients. Volunteers, however, noticed that some clients became less willing to mention spoiled food or missed items, because they no longer saw the same driver repeatedly. The old routes had created informal relationships through which small problems were reported before they became formal complaints. The software therefore improved one measurable efficiency while weakening a feedback channel that had rarely appeared in performance reports.

rc-010. Which of the following best describes the passage's central claim?

- A. The software failed because it did not shorten delivery routes enough to reduce staff workload.
- B. Efficiency improvements can obscure losses in informal communication that matter to service quality.
- C. Older adults are generally reluctant to report problems unless nonprofit managers solicit complaints.
- D. Fixed delivery routes are always preferable to software-generated routes in nonprofit programs.
- E. Performance reports are useful only when they exclude informal feedback from clients.

rc-011. Which of the following, if true, would most strengthen the volunteers' concern?

- A. The software reduced fuel use by grouping stops that were near one another.
- B. Clients who received visits from a consistent driver were more likely to report minor delivery problems promptly.
- C. Some volunteers preferred using printed maps instead of mobile applications.
- D. The nonprofit planned to add several new clients in neighborhoods it already served.
- E. Managers reviewed delivery times more frequently after the software was introduced.

rc-012. Select the sentence that introduces evidence complicating the managers' favorable assessment of the software.

- A. A nonprofit that delivers meals to older adults recently replaced fixed delivery routes with software that assigns stops each morning.
- B. Managers reported that the change shortened average driving time and allowed the same staff to serve more clients.
- C. Volunteers, however, noticed that some clients became less willing to mention spoiled food or missed items, because they no longer saw the same driver repeatedly.
- D. The old routes had created informal relationships through which small problems were reported before they became formal complaints.
- E. The software therefore improved one measurable efficiency while weakening a feedback channel that had rarely appeared in performance reports.

Passage 5

Ecologists studying restored wetlands often count returning bird species as a sign of success. Species counts are useful, but they can mislead when treated as proof that a wetland's ecological functions have recovered. Some birds visit newly flooded areas because open water makes foraging easy, even when the underlying plant community remains simplified. Other species may nest there only briefly if seasonal water levels fluctuate too sharply. For this reason, several researchers recommend pairing bird surveys with measurements of soil chemistry, vegetation structure, and invertebrate abundance. Their point is not that birds are poor indicators, but that a conspicuous response by mobile animals may precede slower changes in the habitat itself.

rc-013. The passage is primarily concerned with

- A. arguing that bird surveys should be abandoned in favor of soil and vegetation measures.
- B. explaining why one visible sign of restoration success should be interpreted with caution.
- C. showing that restored wetlands are usually less stable than natural wetlands.
- D. comparing the nesting habits of wetland birds with those of other mobile animals.
- E. criticizing ecologists for ignoring species counts when evaluating restoration projects.

rc-014. The passage suggests that a restored wetland with many visiting bird species might still be considered incompletely recovered if

- A. its soil, plant, and invertebrate conditions remain unlike those of a functioning wetland.
- B. it attracts species that are difficult for observers to distinguish from one another.
- C. its open water allows some birds to forage more efficiently than they could elsewhere.
- D. bird surveys there are conducted more often than vegetation surveys.
- E. mobile animals respond to habitat changes later than plants and invertebrates do.

rc-015. Which of the following would the researchers mentioned in the passage likely regard as useful additions to bird surveys? Select all that apply.

- A. Assessments of the wetland's plant structure.
- B. Measurements of invertebrate abundance.
- C. Counts of bird species conducted without other habitat data.

Text Completion

tc-001. Although the committee's public statement sounded conciliatory, its private memorandum was markedly [blank_1], dismissing every compromise as naive.

Blank 1

- A. placatory
- B. intransigent
- C. diffident
- D. redundant
- E. methodical

tc-002. The software's interface was so [blank_1] that new users could complete complex tasks without consulting the manual.

Blank 1

- A. intuitive
- B. ornate
- C. volatile
- D. opaque
- E. peripheral

tc-003. The historian's prose is not [blank_1]; even when she contests a rival interpretation, she does so without theatrical denunciation.

Blank 1

- A. polemical
- B. chronological
- C. assiduous
- D. elliptical
- E. judicious

tc-004. The architect's proposal was praised for its (i) [blank_1], but city engineers warned that its technical specifications remained (ii) [blank_2].

Blank 1

- A. ingenuity
- B. redundancy
- C. fragility

Blank 2

- D. impracticable
- E. lavish

F. transparent

tc-005. Because the review board had often approved projects after only cursory discussion, its sudden demand for extensive documentation seemed less a sign of new (i) [blank_1] than of institutional (ii) [blank_2].

Blank 1

- A. scrupulousness
- B. improvisation
- C. candor

Blank 2

- D. continuity
- E. caprice
- F. deference

tc-006. The editor was not trying to (i) [blank_1] the novelist's eccentric style; rather, her notes aimed to make its deliberate oddities more (ii) [blank_2] to readers.

Blank 1

- A. standardize
- B. celebrate
- C. amplify

Blank 2

- D. onerous
- E. discernible
- F. incidental

tc-007. The biographer resists the temptation to make her subject either wholly admirable or wholly contemptible: she (i) [blank_1] his public generosity, documents his private evasions, and refuses to let either body of evidence (ii) [blank_2] the other. The result is a portrait whose moral judgment is (iii) [blank_3] rather than evasive.

Blank 1

- A. acknowledges
- B. fabricates
- C. trivializes

Blank 2

- D. eclipse
- E. corroborate
- F. diversify

Blank 3

- G. nuanced
- H. peremptory
- I. incoherent

tc-008. At first the laboratory's failure to reproduce the celebrated result seemed to (i) [blank_1] the original study. Subsequent audits, however, found that the new experiment had used a contaminated reagent, making the failed replication (ii) [blank_2] as evidence against the earlier finding and leaving the debate largely (iii) [blank_3].

Blank 1

- A. discredit
- B. vindicate
- C. publicize

Blank 2

- D. decisive
- E. irrelevant
- F. redundant

Blank 3

- G. settled
- H. unresolved
- I. anachronistic

tc-009. The essay's opening pages promise a (i) [blank_1] defense of local journalism, but the argument soon becomes oddly (ii) [blank_2]: after listing threats to small newspapers, the author digresses into anecdotes that neither explain those threats nor suggest remedies. What began as advocacy thus ends in (iii) [blank_3].

Blank 1

- A. cogent
- B. perfunctory
- C. hostile

Blank 2

- D. focused
- E. desultory
- F. incisive

Blank 3

- G. diffusion
- H. consensus
- I. exoneration

Sentence Equivalence

se-001. The judge's opinion was unusually [blank_1], avoiding broad pronouncements and deciding only the narrow issue before the court.

- A. sweeping
- B. circumscribed
- C. caustic
- D. limited
- E. ceremonial
- F. expansive

se-002. Because the witness revised her account each time new evidence appeared, the attorney portrayed her testimony as [blank_1].

- A. immutable
- B. malleable
- C. adaptable
- D. meticulous
- E. unassailable
- F. laconic

se-003. The curator expected a modest response to the obscure exhibit, but the opening proved unexpectedly [blank_1], with visitors filling every gallery.

- A. muted
- B. sparsely attended
- C. well attended
- D. tumultuous
- E. popular
- F. understated

se-004. The analyst's forecast was [blank_1], not because it predicted disaster, but because it rested on assumptions the report itself had already undermined.

- A. untenable
- B. dire
- C. indefensible
- D. gloomy
- E. prescient
- F. austere

se-005. Although the philosopher's lectures were demanding, students rarely found them [blank_1], since each difficult claim was followed by a clarifying example.

- A. taxing
- B. opaque
- C. arduous
- D. lucid
- E. inscrutable
- F. methodical

se-006. The startup's founders presented their plan as revolutionary, but investors found it largely [blank_1], a repackaging of services already offered by several competitors.

- A. derivative
- B. novel
- C. imitative
- D. profitable
- E. visionary
- F. precarious

Answer Key and Explanations

rc-001 - Correct: B

The passage emphasizes that imaging can reveal useful features but does not by itself settle what those features mean. Choice A overstates the role of imaging, while C, D, and E shift to issues the passage does not make central.

rc-002 - Correct: B

The conservators treat imaging as a source of hypotheses requiring corroboration, so they would reject the claim that one imaging result is conclusive. The other choices are compatible with the passage's emphasis on combining evidence.

rc-003 - Correct: A, B

The passage explicitly allows that such a shape may be an abandoned plan, a repair, or a stain, so A and B are supported. It does not say that this evidence by itself proves a different authorship, making C too strong.

rc-004 - Correct: C

The passage says trees can cool neighborhoods, but their effect varies with street geometry, circulation, and time of day. A and B are too sweeping, D reverses the emphasis, and E introduces a cause not discussed.

rc-005 - Correct: C

The passage warns that canopy alone can fail to provide nighttime relief if airflow is ignored. A and B may be useful, while D and E reflect the sort of broader planning the passage encourages.

rc-006 - Correct: F

Sentence F explicitly states the planning conclusion: vegetation should be located with attention to geometry and temperature cycles. Sentence E names a distinction planners make, but F directly states the practical implication of that distinction.

rc-007 - Correct: B

The author grants that the images can be comic but argues that they can also mark, extend, or complicate a text. A is too narrow, C and D are unsupported generalizations, and E conflicts with the passage's interpretive examples.

rc-008 - Correct: B

The example supports the claim that a marginal image may do more than amuse: it can visually echo an idea in the text. The other choices add unsupported claims about replacement, frequency, chronology, or fixed meaning.

rc-009 - Correct: A, B

The passage states that marginal images could mark a section and extend an argument by visual analogy, supporting A and B. It emphasizes dependence on context and collaborators, so C is not supported.

rc-010 - Correct: B

The passage contrasts measurable efficiency gains with the loss of an informal reporting channel. A, D, and E are too absolute or contrary to the passage, and C turns a specific observation into a broad generalization.

rc-011 - Correct: B

The volunteers' concern is that rotating drivers weakened a channel for early problem reporting. Choice B directly supports that causal link. A may be an efficiency benefit, and C, D, and E do not address the reporting mechanism.

rc-012 - Correct: C

Sentence C begins with a contrast and supplies the volunteers' observation that complicates the managers' efficiency-focused assessment. Sentence D explains the mechanism, while E states the overall conclusion.

rc-013 - Correct: B

The passage says returning bird species are useful indicators but not conclusive proof of functional recovery. A is too strong, C and D are not the main focus, and E reverses the described practice.

rc-014 - Correct: A

The researchers recommend additional measures because bird presence can occur before slower habitat recovery. Choice A gives the relevant reason. C is a possible reason birds visit but does not by itself establish incomplete recovery; E reverses the passage's timing claim.

rc-015 - Correct: A, B

The passage explicitly recommends pairing bird surveys with vegetation structure and invertebrate abundance, among other measures. C repeats the limited practice the researchers consider insufficient when used alone.

tc-001 - Correct: Blank 1: B

The memorandum dismisses every compromise, so it is uncompromising or intransigent. Placatory is tempting because of the public statement, but the blank describes the contrasting private memorandum.

tc-002 - Correct: Blank 1: A

The ability of new users to complete complex tasks without the manual indicates that the interface was easy to understand, or intuitive. Ornate and opaque may describe interfaces, but they would not explain the users' success.

tc-003 - Correct: Blank 1: A

The clause after the semicolon says she avoids theatrical denunciation, so her prose is not polemical. Judicious is tempting because the behavior is measured, but the sentence says what the prose is not.

tc-004 - Correct: Blank 1: A; Blank 2: D

The contrast between praise and warning suggests that the concept was creative but not technically workable. Ingenuity and impracticable fit this logic; lavish does not explain an engineering warning, and transparent would be positive.

tc-005 - Correct: Blank 1: A; Blank 2: E

The board's abrupt change from cursory approvals to heavy documentation suggests inconsistency rather than genuine carefulness. Scrupulousness names the benign interpretation being rejected, and caprice captures the criticism.

tc-006 - Correct: Blank 1: A; Blank 2: E

The 'not...rather' structure indicates that the editor did not remove the eccentricity but clarified its purpose. Standardize is what she was not doing, and discernible describes oddities made easier to perceive. Amplify would not contrast cleanly with the second clause.

tc-007 - Correct: Blank 1: A; Blank 2: D; Blank 3: G

The sentence praises balance: the biographer acknowledges positive evidence, does not let one kind of evidence eclipse the other, and reaches a nuanced judgment. Peremptory would imply excessive certainty, not careful balance.

tc-008 - Correct: Blank 1: A; Blank 2: E; Blank 3: H

A failed replication would initially seem to discredit the original study. If the replication used a contaminated reagent, it is irrelevant as contrary evidence, so the debate remains unresolved. Decisive and settled contradict the audit's effect.

tc-009 - Correct: Blank 1: A; Blank 2: E; Blank 3: G

The opening promises a strong defense, but the essay wanders into irrelevant anecdotes. Cogent fits the promised argument, desultory fits the wandering execution, and diffusion captures the loss of focus. Focused and incisive contradict the digression.

se-001 - Correct: Blank 1: B, D

Avoiding broad pronouncements and deciding only a narrow issue points to an opinion that is circumscribed or limited. Sweeping and expansive form a tempting pair but mean the opposite in context.

se-002 - Correct: Blank 1: B, C

Repeatedly changing the account in response to evidence makes the testimony seem malleable or adaptable. Immutable and unassailable are nearly favorable in legal contexts but contradict the described revisions.

se-003 - Correct: Blank 1: C, E

Visitors filling every gallery indicates that the opening was well attended or popular. Muted and understated are a tempting pair, but they conflict with the unexpectedly large response.

se-004 - Correct: Blank 1: A, C

The problem is not pessimism but weak assumptions, so the forecast is untenable or indefensible. Dire and gloomy are tempting synonyms, but the sentence explicitly says disaster was not the issue.

se-005 - Correct: Blank 1: B, E

The lectures were difficult but not hard to understand because examples clarified them; opaque and inscrutable fit what students rarely found them to be. Taxing and arduous are tempting synonyms, but the sentence concedes that the lectures were demanding.

se-006 - Correct: Blank 1: A, C

A repackaging of existing services is derivative or imitative. Novel and visionary match the founders' claim but not the investors' assessment; profitable and precarious are not supported by the sentence.